



# Home Printers

## Canon xnu i255

Designers touch

In text printing mode, this entry-level inkjet from Canon, which replaces the older xnu i320 model, was the fastest. The USB 2.0 interface shows its usefulness when printing the same text file in best quality mode—it was twice as fast as the others. Similarly, it printed the image file faster than any other printer in this category. The Canon i255 uses two cartridges and the black printout amounted to Rs 2.44 per page, whereas a colour printout costs Rs 1.44 per page.

On the print-quality front, it showed no jagged edges or smudging. The photo output had good colour reproduction, but overall it was dull and lacked the crispness shown by the HP printers.

Some cosmetic changes have been done to the original design, and it looks a lot better. The bright blue side panels of the older design have been replaced by better-looking grey panels. The Canon i255 comes with a foldable paper input tray that provides enough paper support. The lack of an output tray makes the design smaller. It was the only printer in this category to support USB 2.0.

Installing the printer is quite simple. All you need to do is connect it to the USB port and install the driver from the accompanying CD-ROM. The maintenance tab, in the Printer Properties dialog box, allows you to clean the cartridges, align the print head as well as switch off the printer via software. The status monitor was always wrong when displaying the amount of remaining ink.

Priced at Rs 4,500, the Canon xnu i255 is expensive, but if you need a quality printer, this is it!



- + Great quality printouts and looks good
- No output paper tray

| Canon xnu i255 |       | B- |
|----------------|-------|----|
| Performance    | ▶▶▶▶▶ |    |
| Features       | ▶▶▶▶▶ |    |
| Build quality  | ▶▶▶▶▶ |    |
| Value of money | ▶▶▶▶▶ |    |

## Epson Stylus C43SX

The last parallel samurai

The Epson Stylus C43SX is a spruced up version of the older C41SX. Available with both the USB and parallel interfaces, the one reviewed here is the parallel version—indicated by the suffix 'SX'.

As we expected, it was the slowest, a clear indication of its legacy interface. The Epson C43SX took nearly double the time to print text documents as compared to other printers. While printing combi-documents, it was able to beat some of the

better-configured printers. It took twice the time to print the test photo when compared to the HP and Canon, but was much better than the Lexmark Z605.

Quality-wise, the Epson C43SX was a complete letdown. Despite the rise in its optimised resolution, it couldn't match the print quality displayed by the Canon and HP printers. Jagged edges and smudging were clearly visible. The photo prints were good, with true colour reproduction, but were too bright. The cost for a black page came to about Rs 3.27, and the colour page translates into Rs 2.08 per page.

This model has undergone absolutely no cosmetic change compared to the Epson C41SX, and still offers the same, dated design. Nevertheless, the use of translucent plastic for the cartridge bay and output tray accentuate the otherwise dull looks. The top-loading paper tray can hold about 100 sheets, and the output tray does a good job of holding the printed papers together.

Installing the printer is quite simple and requires the accompanying parallel cable to be hooked on to the computer before you install the driver. Comparatively, the driver installation is not as intuitive as the ones from HP or Canon, but definitely not difficult either. The driver allows for cleaning and maintenance of ink cartridges, and the ink status indicator is fairly accurate.

Priced at Rs 3,250, The Epson Stylus C43SX is one of the cheapest printers available. Given the dated interface this printer has, it's the only available choice for people with legacy computers. However, do keep in mind the average print quality that is on offer.

| Epson Stylus C43SX |       | B- |
|--------------------|-------|----|
| Performance        | ▶▶▶▶▶ |    |
| Features           | ▶▶▶▶▶ |    |
| Build quality      | ▶▶▶▶▶ |    |
| Value for money    | ▶▶▶▶▶ |    |

- + Offers legacy parallel port
- Below par printing quality

## Epson Stylus C63

A mate for the desk

The Epson Stylus C63 was a little slower than its younger sibling—the C43SX—in most of our tests. In text printing, it's reasonably fast, finishing second after the Canon i255. However, in all the other tests it lagged way behind the i255.

Both the printers from Epson perform below par when it comes to quality, but the C63 is better than the C43SX. The text does show jagged edges and smudging, but only to a small extent. Photo printouts reproduced every minute detail properly; however, the image just didn't seem vivid enough. The cost per black page comes to Rs 3.50, and a colour page costs Rs 2.

The Epson C63 uses four separate cartridges, which is good,

